

Word family: **absorb / absorbs / absorbed / absorbing / absorption / absorbent / absorbency / absorber / absorptive / absorbance**

Base word: absorb

Forms: absorbs, absorbed, absorbing

Related forms: absorption, absorbent, absorbency, absorber, absorptive, absorbance

Part of speech: verb (動詞) / related nouns and adjectives (相關名詞及形容詞)

Your sentence:

> “Put simply, tutors earn private income while restaurants **absorb the hidden overhead**.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **absorb** means **to bear or take on a financial cost or loss instead of passing it on to someone else**.

The restaurant receives no direct payment for providing the tutoring space, but it still bears costs such as rent, staff time, seating capacity, utilities, and lost sales.

繁體中文： **承擔；自行吸收成本；承受某項費用或損失而不轉嫁給別人**

中文翻譯：

> “...restaurants **absorb the hidden overhead**.”

「.....餐廳卻要自行**承擔 / 吸收那些隱藏的間接成本**。」

Here:

absorb overhead = 商戶自己承擔相關營運成本，而不是由真正產生這些成本的人支付

1. **absorb = take in liquid, gas, or another substance (物質) — 吸收；吸入**

This is the central physical meaning.

Practice 1

> “The towel **absorbed** the water.”

「毛巾把水**吸收**了。」

Practice 2

> “Dry soil quickly **absorbs** rainwater.”

「乾燥的泥土會迅速**吸收**雨水。」

Practice 3

> “The material can **absorb** large amounts of moisture.”

「這種材料可以**吸收**大量水分。」

absorb = 讓液體、氣體或其他物質進入其內部，而不是只停留在表面

Common:

- * absorb water
- * absorb moisture
- * absorb oil
- * absorb gas
- * absorb chemicals

2. **absorb** = take nutrients/drugs/substances into the body (生物 / 醫學) — 吸收

The body, intestine, roots, cells, etc. can **absorb** substances.

Practice 4

> “The intestine **absorbs** nutrients from food.”

「腸道從食物中**吸收**營養。」

Practice 5

> “Plant roots **absorb** water and minerals from the soil.”

「植物根部從泥土中**吸收**水分和礦物質。」

Practice 6

> “The drug is rapidly **absorbed** into the bloodstream.”

「這種藥物會迅速被**吸收到**血液中。」

This is scientifically established and still belongs to the physical **take-in** branch.

For strict core counting, I would merge #1 and #2.

3. **absorb** = take in light, heat, radiation, sound, etc. (能量) — 吸收光、熱、輻射、聲音等

A material can **absorb** energy rather than reflect, transmit, or release it.

Practice 7

> “Dark surfaces **absorb** more heat.”

「深色表面會**吸收**更多熱能。」

Practice 8

> “The material **absorbs** sound and reduces echoes.”

「這種材料可以**吸收聲音**，減少回音。」

Practice 9

> “The gas **absorbs** infrared radiation.”

「這種氣體會**吸收紅外線輻射**。」

In technical terminology, absorption can involve matter taking up energy from radiation passing through it. ([金書][1])

This is an important physical/scientific branch.

4. **absorb** = take the force of an impact or shock (衝擊) — 吸收衝擊；緩衝

Absorb can refer to taking in mechanical force so that less of the impact reaches something else.

Practice 10

> “The padding helps **absorb** the impact.”

「這層軟墊有助**吸收 / 緩衝衝擊力**。」

Practice 11

> “The suspension system **absorbs** shocks from the road.”

「懸掛系統可以**吸收 / 減輕路面的震動**。」

absorb an impact/shock = 承受並消散部分衝擊能量，減低其影響

This belongs naturally with the physical-energy branch.

5. **absorb punishment/blows** = withstand repeated physical impact (承受) — 承受打擊

In sport or physical description:

Practice 12

> “The boxer was able to **absorb** several heavy blows.”

「那名拳手能夠**承受**幾次重擊。」

Here **absorb** does not mean literally soak something up. It means:

> take the force without immediately being overwhelmed.

For core counting, this is an extension of Meaning 4.

6. **absorb** = learn and understand information (資訊) — 吸收；理解；消化

A very common figurative meaning.

Practice 13

> “It takes time to **absorb** all this information.”

「要**消化 / 吸收**這些資料需要時間。」

Practice 14

> “Students need a chance to **absorb** what they have learned.”

「學生需要時間去**消化吸收**所學內容。」

Practice 15

> “He listened carefully, trying to **absorb** every detail.”

「他仔細聆聽，努力**理解並記住**每個細節。」

absorb information = 把資訊理解、消化並納入自己的知識中

This is one of the strongest everyday figurative senses.

7. **absorb** = completely occupy someone's attention or interest (注意力) — 使全神貫注；吸引全部注意力

Something can **absorb** a person if it completely holds their attention.

Practice 16

> “The puzzle **absorbed** him for hours.”

「這個謎題令他一連幾個小時都**全神貫注**。」

Practice 17

> “Her research completely **absorbed** her.”

「她完全**沉浸於**自己的研究之中。」

absorb someone = 強烈吸引某人的注意力，使其完全投入

This is distinct from merely learning information.

8. **be absorbed in something** = be completely concentrated on it (固定結構) — 專心於；沉浸於

Practice 18

> “She was **absorbed in** a book.”

「她正**全神貫注地看**一本書。」

Practice 19

> “He became so **absorbed in** his work that he forgot the time.”

「他太**投入工作**，連時間也忘記了。」

****be absorbed in = 注意力完全投入某項活動或思想中****

This is one of the most important constructions in the family.

9. ****absorbing = extremely interesting / engrossing (形容詞) — 引人入勝的；令人全神貫注的****

The participle has developed into a useful adjective.

Practice 20

> “It was an ****absorbing**** documentary.”

「那是一齣非常****引人入勝****的紀錄片。」

Practice 21

> “The novel is surprisingly ****absorbing****.”

「這本小說出奇地****吸引人 / 令人投入****。」

****absorbing = 有足夠吸引力令人的注意力完全投入其中****

10. ****absorb = incorporate a person, group, company, territory, etc. into a larger whole (併入) — 吸納；併入；融合****

Another major meaning:

Practice 22

> “The smaller department was ****absorbed into**** a larger division.”

「較小的部門被****併入****一個較大的部門。」

Practice 23

> “The company was eventually ****absorbed into**** the parent group.”

「該公司最終被****併入****母集團。」

Practice 24

> “The expanding city gradually **absorbed** several surrounding villages.”

「不斷擴張的城市逐漸把附近幾個村落**納入其中**。」

absorb X into Y = 使某個較小的單位被納入較大的整體，原有獨立性可能減少或消失

This is a genuinely distinct core branch.

11. **absorb** = successfully accommodate additional people, supply, demand, etc. (容量 / 市場) — 吸納；消化；容納

A system, market, organization, or economy can **absorb** an additional quantity without being overwhelmed.

Practice 25

> “The labour market cannot **absorb** so many new workers at once.”

「勞動市場無法一下子**吸納**這麼多新增勞工。」

Practice 26

> “The market was able to **absorb** the additional supply.”

「市場能夠**消化 / 吸納**新增供應。」

Practice 27

> “The school can **absorb** another hundred students.”

「這間學校還可以**容納 / 吸納**多一百名學生。」

absorb = 把新增的人、貨品、需求、供應等納入現有系統，而不造成重大問題

This is especially useful in economics, business, institutions, and capacity planning.

12. **absorb** = use up a large amount of time, money, resources, capacity, etc. (資源) — 佔用；耗用

Practice 28

> “The project **absorbed** most of the department’s budget.”

「這個項目**耗用了**部門大部分預算。」

Practice 29

> “Administrative work **absorbs** a great deal of staff time.”

「行政工作**佔用了**員工大量時間。」

absorb resources = 大量使用或消耗現有資源 / 時間 / 金錢 / 能力

This differs from **bear a cost**:

* absorb a budget = use it up

* absorb a cost = bear it

The contexts usually make the distinction clear.

13. **absorb** = bear a cost, loss, increase, or financial impact (商業) — 承擔 ; 吸收成本 / 損失

This is the **exact branch** in your passage.

Practice 30 — Original

> “Restaurants **absorb** the hidden overhead.”

「餐廳自行**承擔 / 吸收**隱藏的間接成本。」

Practice 31

> “The retailer decided to **absorb** the extra shipping cost.”

「零售商決定自行**承擔**額外運費。」

Practice 32

> “The company **absorbed** the loss rather than passing it on to customers.”

「公司自行**承擔損失**，沒有把成本轉嫁給顧客。」

absorb a cost/loss = 自己承擔該筆財務負擔，而不是由另一方支付或補償

Common:

- * absorb the cost
- * absorb a loss
- * absorb an increase
- * absorb overhead
- * absorb additional expenses

14. **absorb** = withstand a broader shock/change without serious disruption (經濟 / 系統) — 承受；消化衝擊

The financial and physical senses extend into systems.

Practice 33

> “The business was strong enough to **absorb** the sudden increase in costs.”

「這家企業有足夠實力**承受**成本突然增加的衝擊。」

Practice 34

> “The network can **absorb** short-term fluctuations in demand.”

「這個網絡可以**承受 / 消化**短期需求波動。」

absorb a shock = 接受並消化衝擊，使其不致造成同等程度的破壞

This connects the physical “absorb impact” metaphor with business/economic resilience.

15. **absorption costing** (會計) — 吸收成本法 / 完全成本法

This deserves explicit attention because your passage places **absorb** directly beside **overhead**.

In managerial accounting, **absorption costing** is a product-costing method in which product cost includes direct costs plus variable and fixed manufacturing overhead. It is also called **full costing**. ([OpenStax][2])

Example

> “The company uses **absorption costing** to value its inventory.”

「公司採用**吸收成本法 / 完全成本法**計算存貨成本。」

The word **absorption** here reflects the idea that manufacturing overhead is **absorbed into / allocated to the cost of products**.

Important

Your passage:

> restaurants **absorb the hidden overhead**

is **ordinary business English**, meaning:

> restaurants **bear the cost**.

It is **not specifically saying that the restaurant is using absorption costing**.

That distinction is important.

16. **absorbance (光譜學) — 吸光度**

A specialist scientific family word.

In spectroscopy, **absorbance** is a quantitative measure related to how much light is absorbed; NIST formally defines it using the negative logarithm of transmittance. ([NIST出版系列][3])

Common:

- * optical absorbance
- * measure absorbance
- * absorbance spectrum

absorbance = 吸光度

This is a separate technical noun and should not be confused with general **absorption**.

Related form: **absorption**

Absorption is the main noun and mirrors many senses of **absorb**.

Physical

> water absorption
> nutrient absorption
> heat absorption

= **吸收**

Mental

> absorption of information

= **對資訊的吸收 / 理解**

Attention

> “He was lost in complete absorption.”

= **全神貫注 / 沉浸**

Organizational

> absorption of one company into another

= **併入 / 整合**

Costing

> absorption costing

= **吸收成本法 / 完全成本法**

Related form: **absorbent**

Absorbent means able to absorb liquid easily.

Practice 35

> “Use an **absorbent** cloth.”

「使用一塊**吸水性強的**布。」

Common:

* absorbent material

* absorbent paper

* highly absorbent

****absorbent = 能夠有效吸收液體的****

Related form: ****absorbency****

****Absorbency**** means the ability/capacity to absorb liquid.

Practice 36

> “The fabric has excellent ****absorbency****.”

「這種布料的****吸水性****很好。」

Related form: ****absorber****

An ****absorber**** is something that absorbs.

The most familiar compound is:

> ****shock absorber****

= ****避震器 / 減震器****

Practice 37

> “The car needs a new shock ****absorber****.”

「這部車需要更換新的****避震器****。」

Scientific contexts also use ****absorber**** for substances/components that absorb radiation, sound, etc.

Related form: ****absorptive****

****Absorptive**** means relating to or having the capacity for absorption.

Common specialist examples:

- * absorptive capacity
- * absorptive process
- * absorptive surface

In management/business research, **absorptive capacity** can also describe an organization's ability to recognize, assimilate, and use new knowledge.

This is useful but more specialist than **absorbent**.

Important distinction: **absorb vs soak up**

soak up

is more informal and often physical:

> a towel soaks up water

absorb

works in both physical and highly abstract contexts:

- * absorb water
- * absorb heat
- * absorb information
- * absorb costs
- * absorb a company

So **absorb** is considerably broader.

Important distinction: **absorb vs consume**

consume

means use something up.

absorb

can mean use up resources, but also means take something into a system.

> "The project consumed most of the budget."

and

> “The project absorbed most of the budget.”

are close.

But:

> “The sponge absorbed water.”

cannot normally be replaced by **consumed**.

Important distinction: **absorb vs understand**

understand

means comprehend something.

absorb

suggests more than momentary comprehension:

> taking information in, processing it, and mentally retaining it.

> “Give students time to absorb the material.”

= 給學生時間真正消化內容。

Important distinction: **absorb vs memorize**

memorize

means deliberately commit information to memory.

absorb

can happen more naturally and includes understanding.

Someone may absorb the main ideas without memorizing every word.

Important distinction: **absorb vs integrate**

For organizations/groups:

****integrate****

emphasizes bringing parts together so that they function together.

****absorb****

often suggests one entity is taken ****into a larger existing entity****.

> “The subsidiary was absorbed into the parent company.”

The smaller entity may lose much of its separate identity.

Important distinction: ****absorb vs accommodate****

For capacity:

****accommodate****

means have enough room/capacity for something.

****absorb****

suggests taking the additional amount into the existing system without serious disruption.

> accommodate 500 students

> absorb a sudden increase in student numbers

Important distinction: ****absorb vs bear — costs****

****bear a cost****

= be responsible for paying/suffering the cost.

****absorb a cost****

often additionally implies:

> the cost arises, but you accept it internally instead of passing it on.

Compare:

> “The customer bears the cost.”

vs.

> “The company absorbed the cost rather than raising prices.”

This nuance is exactly relevant to your passage.

Important distinction: **absorb vs offset**

absorb

= take/bear the negative effect.

offset

= counterbalance it with something else.

> “The company absorbed the higher costs.”

= 公司承擔較高成本。

> “Higher sales offset the higher costs.”

= 較高銷售額抵銷了較高成本。

Different concepts.

Important distinction: **absorb vs adsorb — science**

This spelling distinction matters.

absorb / absorption

generally involves something being taken **into** another material/body.

adsorb / adsorption

refers specifically to molecules accumulating at a **surface or interface**. IUPAC defines adsorption in terms of increased concentration at an interface. ([金書][4])

A useful learner shortcut is:

> **absorb = into**

> **adsorb = onto the surface**

though specialist scientific definitions can be more nuanced.

Grammar note: **absorb + direct object**

The verb is normally transitive:

> absorb water

> absorb heat

> absorb information

> absorb costs

> absorb a company

Grammar note: **be absorbed into**

For integration:

> “The unit was absorbed into a larger department.”

= 被併入較大的部門。

Grammar note: **be absorbed in/by**

For attention:

> absorbed in a book

> absorbed in thought

> absorbed by the problem

absorbed in is particularly common.

Do not confuse:

> **water is absorbed by the cloth**

where ****by**** identifies the physical absorber,

with:

> ****she is absorbed in the book****

where it means she is completely engrossed.

Countability note

****Absorb**** is a verb.

****absorption****

usually uncountable when describing a process:

> absorption of nutrients

> heat absorption

****absorbency****

normally uncountable:

> high absorbency

****absorber****

countable:

> an absorber

> two shock absorbers

****absorbance****

can be treated as a measurable scientific quantity:

> an absorbance of 0.5

Family-extension note

The practical modern family includes:

* **absorb**
 * **absorbs**
 * **absorbed**
 * **absorbing**
 * **absorption**
 * **absorbent**
 * **absorbency**
 * **absorber**

Important specialist forms:

* **absorptive**
 * **absorbance**

Useful constructions:

* absorb water/moisture
 * absorb nutrients
 * absorb heat/light/sound
 * absorb impact/shock
 * absorb information
 * be absorbed in
 * absorb a company into another
 * absorb new workers/supply
 * absorb resources
 * absorb a cost/loss
 * absorption costing
 * shock absorber

The word has a remarkably consistent underlying metaphor:

> **something enters, is taken into, or is internally accommodated by something else**

But modern English has developed several branches sufficiently distinct to deserve separate learner treatment.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
----- -----	
absorb — liquid/substance	把液體、氣體或物質吸入 / 納入自身內部
absorb — biology	身體、腸道、細胞、植物等吸收營養、藥物、水分等
absorb — energy	吸收光、熱、聲音、輻射等能量
absorb — impact/shock	承受並緩衝 / 消散衝擊力
absorb — information	理解、消化並記住資訊 / 知識
absorb — attention	完全吸引 / 佔據某人的注意力

be absorbed in	全神貫注於；沉浸於	
absorb — incorporate	把較小單位、人群、公司等納入較大的整體	
absorb — capacity/market	吸納新增的人、供應、需求等而不造成重大問題	
absorb — resources	大量耗用 / 佔用時間、金錢、容量等	
absorb — cost/loss	自行承擔成本或損失，而不是把它轉嫁給其他人	
absorb — broader shock	承受並消化變化 / 衝擊，使其不致造成同等程度破壞	
absorption costing	把製造間接成本等納入產品成本的完全 / 吸收成本法	
absorbent	能有效吸收液體的	
absorbency	吸收液體的能力 / 吸水性	
absorber	吸收 / 緩衝某種東西的裝置或物件；如 shock absorber	
absorbance	光譜學的吸光度	

For your original sentence

> “Tutors earn private income while restaurants ****absorb the hidden overhead****.”

The exact meaning is:

****absorb = 餐廳實際承擔由補習活動造成的間接營運成本，而沒有把這些成本收回或轉嫁給補習老師 / 學生****

So:

> ****absorb the hidden overhead****

= ****自行吸收 / 承擔隱藏的間接成本****

There is a useful contrast with the previous word ****shift****:

> ****shift a cost onto someone****

> = 把成本****轉嫁****給另一方

whereas:

> ****absorb a cost****

> = 自己把成本****承擔下來****

For your database, I would count ****7 genuinely useful core meanings**** for ****absorb****:

1. ****take in a liquid, substance, nutrient, etc.****
2. ****take in energy or physical impact — heat, light, sound, shock****
3. ****take in and mentally understand information****
4. ****completely occupy attention — be absorbed in****
5. ****incorporate something into a larger whole****
6. ****accommodate/take up additional people, supply, demand, or resources****
7. ****bear a cost, loss, or shock internally rather than passing it on****

I would keep ****use up time/money/capacity**** closely attached to #6, while preserving ****absorption costing, absorbance, absorbent, absorbency, absorber**** as important family/domain extensions rather than inflating the everyday verb count.

[1]: https://goldbook.iupac.org/terms/view/A00036?utm_source=chatgpt.com "IUPAC - absorption (A00036)"

[2]: https://openstax.org/books/principles-managerial-accounting/pages/6-5-compare-and-contrast-variable-and-absorption-costing?utm_source=chatgpt.com "6.5 Compare and Contrast Variable and Absorption Costing - Principles of Accounting, Volume 2: Managerial Accounting | OpenStax"

[3]: https://nvlpubs.nist.gov/nistpubs/Legacy/SP/nistspecialpublication260-140.pdf?utm_source=chatgpt.com "Standard Reference Materials : Technical specifications for certification of spectrophotometric NTRMs"

[4]: https://goldbook.iupac.org/terms/view/A00155?utm_source=chatgpt.com "IUPAC - adsorption (A00155)"